

Eternal Sonship

doc-eternal-sonship
Christology · Person · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.979
confidence medium

Statement under examination

The Son is eternally the Son (co-eternal and co-equal with the Father), not adopted or begun in time.

In plain language

Two sets of words pull in different directions, which is why this question is genuinely contested at the text level. One set clearly puts the Son before the created order. John 1:1 uses the durative 'was', the ongoing past form of the verb 'to be' (eimi), three times for 'the Word' (logos) at the beginning, while verse 3 switches to 'came to be' for created things, so the Word sits on the uncreated side. John 17:5 and 17:24 have Jesus speak of glory he had and of the Father loving 'me' before the world existed and before its foundation. Colossians 1:15-17 makes the Son the one in whom, through whom, and for whom everything was made, and before all things. Hebrews 1:6 already calls him 'the firstborn' (prototokos) when God brings him into the world. The word 'only-begotten' or 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenes) is used elsewhere of ordinary only-children, so it means unique, not created, and the verbs of sending and giving (1 John 4:9, John 3:16) act on a Son who is already unique. The other set of words attaches sonship to a moment. Psalm 2:7 says 'today I have begotten you', using the begetting verb 'to bear, beget' (yalad), whose ordinary sense across hundreds of uses is literal physical birth, and it sits inside a royal decree. Hebrews 1:5, Hebrews 5:5, and Acts 13:33 quote this with 'today' (semeron) and a perfect 'have begotten' (gegenneka, from gennao), and Acts ties the today to the resurrection, while Hebrews 1:5 also quotes the royal adoption promise 'I will be his father, he shall be my son'. Luke 1:35 says the child to be born will be called Son of God. The begetting and title words by themselves do not say whether sonship is eternal or begun at an event. The verdict lands on affirm because the durative and before-creation words describe a relation already in place, and the begetting texts read naturally as a declaration or enthronement of an already existing Son. But because the begetting vocabulary genuinely carries an origin sense and the canon applies it to a point in time, the confidence is medium and readers who weight those texts as constitutive reach a different conclusion.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1121	בן	ben	son	
H2706	חוק	choq	statute	129
H3117	יום	yom	day	
H3205	יָלַד	yalad	to beget	466
H7069	קָנָה	qanah	to buy	
G0025	ἀγαπάω	agapaō	to love	
G0165	αἰών	aion	an age	129
G0450	ἀνίστημι	anistēmi	to arise	

G0541	ἀπαύγασμα	apaugasma	radiance	
G0649	ἀποστέλλω	apostellō	to send	
G0746	ἀρχή	arche	beginning	58
G0846	αὐτός	autos	it/s/he	
G1080	γεννάω	gennao	to beget	98
G1223	διά	dia	through/because of	
G1325	δίδωμι	didōmi	to give	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	
G1504	εἰκών	eikon	image	23
G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G1519	εἰς	eis	toward	
G1521	εἰσάγω	eisagō	to bring in	
G1722	ἐν	en	in/on/among	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G2362	θρόνος	thronos	throne	64
G2564	καλέω	kaleō	to call	
G2602	καταβολή	katabolē	beginning	
G2889	κόσμος	kosmos	world	
G2936	κτίζω	ktizo	to create	15
G2937	κτίσις	ktisis	creation	19
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3439	μονογενής	monogenes	unique	9
G3625	οἰκουμένη	oikoumenē	world	
G3778	οὗτος	ohutos	this/he/she/it	
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	
G3992	πέμπω	pempō	to send	
G4253	πρό	pro	before	48
G4314	πρός	pros	to/with	
G4416	πρωτότοκος	prototokos	firstborn	9
G4594	σήμερα	sēmeron	today	
G5207	υἱός	huios	son	386
G5287	ὑπόστασις	hupostasis	confidence/essence	
G5481	χαρακτήρ	charaktēr	reproduction	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

One body of vocabulary places the Son before creation and inside the divine being. John 1:1 uses the ongoing past form of the verb 'to be' (eimi, morph V-IAI-3S, the imperfect, an ongoing or repeated past action) three times for 'the Word' (ho logos) at 'the beginning' (arche), contrasted with the completed past form (aorist, a completed past action) of 'to come to be' (ginomai) for created things. John 17:5 and 17:24 set shared glory and the Father's love for 'me' 'before the world existed' (pro tou ton kosmon einai) and 'before the foundation of the world' (pro katabolēs kosmou). Colossians 1:15-17 makes the Son the sphere, agent, and goal of all creation and 'before all things' (pro pantōn). Hebrews 1:6 calls him 'the firstborn' (ton prōtotokon) already when God brings him into the world. The sending verbs act on a Son already 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenēs), with 'I have sent' (apostellō) in the perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) in 1 John 4:9, and 'he gave' (didōmi) in the aorist (a completed past action) in John 3:16. But a second body of vocabulary, the begetting verbs 'to bear, beget' (yalad) in Psalm 2:7 (in the qal, the simple active form of the Hebrew verb, perfect form) and 'to beget' (gennaō) in Hebrews 1:5, Hebrews 5:5, and Acts 13:33 (perfect 'I have begotten' (gegennēka) with 'today' (sēmeron)), is attached by the canon to a moment in time, the resurrection and enthronement, and Hebrews 1:5b quotes the Davidic adoption formula of 2 Samuel 7:14. The begetting words alone do not rank these two patterns, so the affirm rests on the durative (ongoing) and pre-creation terms, not on the begetting terms.

Scripture

John.1.1 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0746 ἀρχή, G3056 λόγος, G1510 εἰμί, G2316 θεός

Force. 'In the beginning was the Word' (ἐν ἀρχῇ ἦν ὁ λόγος), with 'was' (ἦν) tagged V-IAI-3S (imperfect of 'to be' (εἰμί), an ongoing or repeated past action) three times, placing 'the Word' (Logos) in ongoing, continuous being at the absolute origin, with the 'toward God' (πρὸς τὸν θεόν) relation. Verse 3 shifts to the completed past form (aorist, a completed past action) 'came to be' (ἐγένετο) for created things, so 'the Word' (Logos) stands on the uncreated side of the 'was' versus 'came-to-be' contrast.

John.1.2 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3778 οὗτος, G1510 εἰμί, G0746 ἀρχή, G4314 πρὸς

Force. 'This one was in the beginning toward God' (οὗτος ἦν ἐν ἀρχῇ πρὸς τὸν θεόν) repeats the ongoing past form 'was' (ἦν, imperfect of 'to be', an ongoing or repeated past action) and the 'toward' (πρὸς) relation, locking the Father and 'Word' (Logos) distinction into the pre-creation frame before any begetting language appears.

John.1.14 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3439 μονογενής, G3962 πατήρ, G1391 δόξα

Force. 'glory as of the only one (one-of-a-kind) from a father' (δόξαν ὡς μονογενοῦς παρὰ πατρός) pairs 'one-of-a-kind' (μονογενής, monogenes) with 'from a father' (παρὰ πατρός). The same word 'one-of-a-kind' (μονογενής, monogenes) is used in the canon of ordinary only-children (Luke 7:12, Luke 8:42, Hebrews 11:17 of Isaac), so it lexically means 'only, unique-kind', not 'created' or 'originated'.

John.1.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3439 μονογενής, G2316 θεός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. 'the only-one (one-of-a-kind) God' (μονογενὴς θεός, in the earliest witnesses) or 'the only-one (one-of-a-kind) Son' (ὁ μονογενὴς υἱός, in the Byzantine tradition), 'the one being in the bosom of the Father' (ὁ ὢν εἰς τὸν κόλπον τοῦ πατρός). The present participle 'the one being' (ὁ ὢν) marks ongoing relational location, not an event of becoming Son. Both variant readings apply 'one-of-a-kind' (μονογενής, monogenes) to the Son.

John.17.5 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1391 δόξα, G4253 πρό, G3844 παρά, G2889 κόσμος

Force. 'glorify me, Father, alongside yourself with the glory which I was having alongside you before the world existed' (δόξασόν με σύ, πάτερ, παρά σεαυτῷ τῇ δόξῃ ἣ εἶχον πρὸ τοῦ τὸν κόσμον εἶναι παρά σοί). The ongoing past form 'I was having' (εἶχον, imperfect, an ongoing or repeated past action) with 'before' (πρό) plus the 'of-which' (genitive, the 'from-X or of-X' grammatical form) places shared glory and the 'alongside you' (παρά σοί) relation prior to the existence of 'the world' (κόσμος, kosmos).

John.17.24 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0025 ἀγαπάω, G4253 πρό, G2602 καταβολή, G2889 κόσμος

Force. 'you loved me before the foundation of the world' (ἡγάπησάς με πρὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου), with the completed past form 'you loved' (ἡγάπησάς, aorist, a completed past action) and 'before the foundation of the world' (πρὸ καταβολῆς κόσμου) locating the Father's love directed at 'me' before the foundation of the world. The object of that love is the personal 'me' of the speaker, prior to creation.

Col.1.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1504 εἰκών, G4416 πρωτότοκος, G2937 κτίσις

Force. 'image of the invisible God, firstborn of all creation' (εἰκὼν τοῦ θεοῦ τοῦ ἀοράτου, πρωτότοκος πάσης κτίσεως). 'Firstborn' (πρωτότοκος, prototokos, 9 occurrences) carries both birth-order 'firstborn' (Luke 2:7) and rank or preeminence (read against verse 16 'because in him all things were created' (ὅτι ἐν αὐτῷ ἐκτίσθη τὰ πάντα)). The grounding 'because' (ὅτι) makes him agent of all creation, so the 'of-which' form (genitive, the 'from-X or of-X' grammatical form) is of rank, not of membership in 'creation' (κτίσις, ktisis).

Col.1.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2936 κτίζω, G3956 πᾶς, G1722 ἐν, G1223 διά, G1519 εἰς

Force. 'because in him all things were created' (ὅτι ἐν αὐτῷ ἐκτίσθη τὰ πάντα), then the perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) 'all things through him and toward him have been created' (τὰ πάντα δι' αὐτοῦ καὶ εἰς αὐτὸν ἔκτισται). The triad 'in' (ἐν), 'through' (διά), 'toward' (εἰς) makes the Son the sphere, agent, and goal of all creation. If 'all things' (τὰ πάντα) is created in and through him, he is not a member of 'all things' (τὰ πάντα).

Col.1.17 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0846 αὐτός, G1510 εἰμί, G4253 πρό, G3956 πᾶς

Force. 'and he himself is before all things, and in him all things hold together' (καὶ αὐτός ἐστιν πρὸ πάντων, καὶ τὰ πάντα ἐν αὐτῷ συνέστηκεν). The emphatic 'he himself' (αὐτός) with the present-tense 'is' (ἐστιν, ongoing, simple statement of fact) plus 'before' (πρό) marks personal priority over 'all things' (τὰ πάντα), and the perfect 'have held together' (συνέστηκεν, a completed action whose result still stands) marks his ongoing sustaining function.

Heb.1.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4416 πρωτότοκος, G3625 οἰκουμένη, G1521 εἰσάγω

Force. 'and when again he brings the firstborn into the inhabited world' (ὅταν δὲ πάλιν εἰσαγάγῃ τὸν πρωτότοκον εἰς τὴν οἰκουμένην). The Son is already named 'the firstborn' (τὸν πρωτότοκον) at the point God brings him into 'the inhabited world' (τὴν οἰκουμένην), so the firstborn status precedes his entry into the world rather than being conferred by it.

Heb.1.8 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5207 υἱός, G2316 θεός, G2362 θρόνος, G0165 αἰών

Force. 'but to the Son: your throne, O God, is for the age of the age' (πρὸς δὲ τὸν υἱόν: ὁ θρόνος σου, ὁ θεός, εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα τοῦ αἰῶνος). The Father addresses the Son with 'O God' (ὁ θεός, in the direct-address form (vocative, the 'O X' form of address)) and an everlasting throne, citing Psalm 45:6 (store cross-ref Hebrews 1:8 to Psalm 45:6) as direct divine address to the Son.

Heb.1.3 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5481 χαρακτήρ, G5287 ὑπόστασις, G0541 ἀπαύγασμα

Force. 'radiance of the glory and exact impress of his being' (ἀπαύγασμα τῆς δόξης καὶ χαρακτήρ τῆς ὑποστάσεως αὐτοῦ). 'Radiance' (ἀπαύγασμα, apaugasma) and 'exact impress' (χαρακτήρ, charakter) describe origin-from but not temporal beginning. Radiance is co-temporal with its source, so the lexis describes derivation without a point of coming-to-be.

1John.4.9 · **for** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3439 μονογενής, G5207 υἱός, G0649 ἀποστέλλω

Force. 'God has sent his only-one (one-of-a-kind) Son into the world' (τὸν υἱὸν αὐτοῦ τὸν μονογενῆ ἀπέσταλκεν ὁ θεός εἰς τὸν κόσμον). 'He has sent' (ἀπέσταλκεν) is tagged V-RAI-3S (perfect, a completed action whose result still stands), and the Son is already qualified 'only-one (one-of-a-kind)' (μονογενῆ, monogenes) when sent. The sending acts on an existing unique Son, it does not make him Son.

John.3.16 · **for** · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3439 μονογενής, G5207 υἱός, G1325 δίδωμι

Force. 'he gave his only-one (one-of-a-kind) Son' (τὸν υἱὸν αὐτοῦ τὸν μονογενῆ ἔδωκεν). 'He gave' (ἔδωκεν) is tagged V-AAI-3S (aorist, a completed past action), acting on a Son already designated 'only-one (one-of-a-kind)' (μονογενῆ, monogenes). The giving does not constitute the sonship.

Ps.2.7 · **complicates** · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H3205 יְלִיד, H1121 בן, H2706 קִנִּי, H3117 הוֹדִי

Force. The Hebrew frames the line as a 'decree' (קִנִּי, choq) the LORD spoke: 'you are my son, today I have begotten you' (יְלִידִי הוֹדִיתִי הַיּוֹם). 'I have begotten you' (יְלִידִיתִי) is the verb 'to bear, beget' (yalad) tagged HVqp1cs (qal, the simple active form of the Hebrew verb, perfect form, first-person singular with second-masculine-singular suffix). 'To bear, beget' (yalad) occurs 466 times and dominantly means literal physical begetting (Genesis genealogies), so its native sense is point-of-origin, but here it is the content of a decree spoken 'today' (הַיּוֹם), a coronation idiom. The word carries origin sense but its frame is enthronement declaration.

Heb.1.5 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1080 γεννάω, G5207 υἱός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. 'you are my son, today I have begotten you' (υἱός μου εἶ σύ, ἐγὼ σήμερον γεγέννηκά σε), with 'I have begotten' (γεγέννηκά, from 'to beget' (gennaō)) tagged V-RAI-1S (perfect, a completed action whose result still stands) plus the adverb 'today' (σήμερον, semeron). The verse then quotes 2 Samuel 7:14 (store cross-ref Hebrews 1:5 to 2 Samuel 7:14) in the future tense, 'I will be to him for a father and he himself will be to me for a son' (ἔσομαι αὐτῷ εἰς πατέρα καὶ αὐτὸς ἔσται μοι εἰς υἱόν), the Davidic covenant formula. The begetting plus 'today' plus future adoption formula is a royal-installation matrix.

Acts.13.33 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1080 γεννάω, G0450 ἀνίστημι, G4594 σήμερον

Force. 'having raised up Jesus ... you are my son, today I have begotten you' (ἀναστήσας Ἰησοῦν ... υἱός μου εἶ σύ, ἐγὼ σήμερον γεγέννηκά σε). The completed past participle (aorist participle) 'having raised up' (ἀναστήσας) ties the 'today' (σήμερον, semeron) of the begetting decree explicitly to the resurrection day, so the canon itself applies the begetting language of Psalm 2:7 to a moment in time.

Luke.1.35 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2564 καλέω, G5207 υἱός, G1080 γεννάω

Force. 'therefore also the holy one being born will be called Son of God' (διὸ καὶ τὸ γεννώμενον ἅγιον κληθήσεται υἱὸς θεοῦ). The future passive 'will be called' (κληθήσεται) and the present participle 'the one being born' (τὸ γεννώμενον, from 'to beget' (gennaō)) attach the title 'Son of God' to the one conceived and born, so the sonship title is here predicated of the incarnate child. The verb 'is called', which does not by itself decide whether the title names a pre-existing relation or originates at birth.

Prov.8.22 · complicates · genre: wisdom · figures: personification

Key terms. H7069 קָנָה

Force. 'the LORD acquired/possessed me as the beginning of his way' (יְהוָה קָנָהנִי רִאשִׁית דְּרָכָיו). The verb 'to possess, acquire' (qanah) carries 'possess' or 'acquire' as well as 'create'. The Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) renders this as 'he created me' (ἐκτίσέν με), which was used against eternal sonship, but the subject is personified Wisdom in poetry, and identifying that figure with the Son is a typological judgment, not a direct lemma identification of the Son.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.1.1	John.1.2	tsk	1
John.1.1	John.1.18	tsk	1
John.1.1	John.10.30	tsk	1
John.17.5	John.17.24	tsk	1
John.17.5	John.1.1	tsk	1
Col.1.15	Col.1.16	tsk	1
Col.1.16	Col.1.15	tsk	1
Col.1.17	Col.1.15	tsk	1
Col.1.15	Exod.24.10	tsk	1
Heb.1.8	Ps.45.6	tsk	1
Heb.1.8	Isa.9.7	tsk	1
Heb.1.5	Heb.5.5	tsk	1
Heb.1.5	2Sam.7.14	tsk	1
Ps.2.7	Matt.3.17	tsk	1
Ps.2.7	John.1.14	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Ps.2.7 · addressed

'today I have begotten you' (הַיּוֹם יָלַדְתִּי אֶתְּךָ) uses 'to bear, beget' (yalad) in the qal (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb), perfect form, whose dominant canon sense across 466 occurrences is literal physical begetting, a point of origin. Here it is the content of a 'decree' (q̄n, choq) spoken 'today' (הַיּוֹם), the royal-coronation idiom of the Davidic Psalms. The begetting word supplies an origin sense, but the 'today' frame redirects it to an enthronement declaration of an already addressed son, so the verse neither establishes nor excludes eternal sonship on lexis alone.

Heb.1.5 · addressed

'today I have begotten you' (σήμερον γεγέννηκά σε, with the perfect form 'I have begotten' from 'to beget' (gennaō), a completed action whose result still stands, plus 'today' (semeron)) is paired in the same verse with the future Davidic adoption formula of 2 Samuel 7:14, 'I will be to him for a father, he will be to me for a son' (ἐσομαι ... εἰς πατέρα, ἔσται ... εἰς υἱόν). Acts 13:33 fixes the 'today' (σήμερον, semeron) to the resurrection. So the canon applies the begetting and son-installation language to a moment in time, which is why the begetting texts cannot by themselves carry the eternal verdict. The affirm rests on the separate durative (ongoing) and pre-creation vocabulary, not on these verses.

Acts.13.33 · addressed

'having raised up Jesus' (ἀναστήσας Ἰησοῦν) fixes the 'today' (σήμερον, semeron) of Psalm 2:7 to the resurrection day. This corroborates that the begetting decree is applied as public declaration at an event, not as a statement about the Son coming into existence. It complicates but does not overturn, since the Johannine and Pauline pre-creation terms describe a relation already in place.

Luke.1.35 · unaddressed

'will be called Son of God' (κληθήσεται υἱὸς θεοῦ, future passive) attaches the title 'Son of God' to 'the one being born' (τὸ γεννώμενον, from 'to beget' (gennaō)), the one being conceived and born. The verb 'is called' does not lexically decide whether the title names a pre-existing relation now revealed in the incarnation or originates at conception. The word underdetermines the question, so this remains unresolved at the lexical level and is the clearest single-verse pressure point against an eternal reading.

Col.1.15 · addressed

'firstborn of all creation' (πρωτότοκος πάσης κτίσεως, from 'firstborn' (prototokos) and 'creation' (ktisis)) in isolation can read as first member of 'creation' (κτίσις, ktisis). The causal 'because' (ὅτι) in verse 16 makes him the agent in whom and through whom 'all things' (τὰ πάντα) was created, which rules out membership in 'all things' (τὰ πάντα). 'Firstborn' (πρωτότοκος, prototokos, 9 occurrences) bears both birth-order and rank senses, and Hebrews 1:6 shows the Son is already 'firstborn' (πρωτότοκος, prototokos) before being brought into the world, so 'rank' or 'preeminence' is the contextually forced sense here.

Prov.8.22 · addressed

Hebrew 'he acquired/possessed me' (יָקַח, from 'to possess, acquire' (qanah)) is ambiguous between 'acquire' and 'create', and the Greek Old Testament's (Septuagint, LXX) 'he created me' (ἐκτίσέν με) was used in the fourth-century dispute. Lexically the identification of personified Wisdom with the pre-incarnate Son is a typological judgment, not a direct lemma identification, so this verse does not by itself overturn the Johannine and Pauline pattern.

John.14.28 · addressed

'the Father is greater than I' (ὁ πατήρ μείζων μου ἐστίν) has been read against co-equal sonship. 'Greater' (μείζων, meizon) in this discourse follows the sending and return frame ('I am going to the Father' (ὑπάγω πρὸς τὸν πατέρα)), addressing ordering during the incarnation, not a temporal-beginning vocabulary for the Son.

Concordance traversed

G3439, G5207, G1080, H3205, G3056, G0746, G1510, G4253, G4416, G1504, G2936, G2937, G2362, G0165, G0649, G3992, G1325, H2706, H1121

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: True · ECM status: ecm-shadow

monogenes-theos-vs-huiois at John.1.18: impact minor. The earliest witnesses (P66, P75, Sinaiticus, Vaticanus) read 'only-one (one-of-a-kind) God' (μονογενῆς θεός, with 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenes)), the Byzantine tradition reads 'the only-one (one-of-a-kind) Son' (ὁ μονογενῆς υἱός). Both apply 'one-of-a-kind' (μονογενῆς, monogenes) to the Son 'in the bosom of the Father' with the present participle 'the one being' (ὁ ὢν), so the verdict holds across both readings.

autou-vs-sou at Heb.1.8: impact none. The variant at the end of the verse reads 'scepter of his kingdom' (ῥάβδος τῆς βασιλείας αὐτοῦ) versus 'scepter of your kingdom' (with σου, your). Either reading preserves the address 'your throne, O God' (ὁ θρόνος σου, ὁ θεός) to the Son, so the everlasting kingdom predication is undisturbed.

monogene-placement at John.3.16: impact none. Minor word-order variants do not affect 'he gave the only-one (one-of-a-kind) Son' (τὸν υἱὸν τὸν μονογενῆ ἔδωκεν, with 'one-of-a-kind' (monogene)). The unique-Son predicate and the completed past form 'he gave' (aorist of giving, a completed past action) are stable.

The critical edition of New Testament textual variants (ECM apparatus) is not yet published for John, Colossians, Psalms, or Hebrews (none of the anchors fall in the ingested 3 John window). Variant assessments are drawn from the NA28 apparatus and INTF NTVMR images, not from CBGM data.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. trinitarian_classical, incarnational_sonship, enthronement_sonship, subordinationist, adoptionist

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

trinitarian_classical: affirms_eternal_sonship · Reads the ongoing past form 'was' (ἦν, imperfect of 'to be', an ongoing or repeated past action), the 'before' (πρό) and 'alongside' (παρά) prepositions with creation-frame 'of-which' forms (genitives, the 'from-X or of-X' grammatical form) in John 17:5, 17:24, and Colossians 1:17, the 'firstborn' (πρωτότοκος, prototokos) that precedes the Son's entry into the world in Hebrews 1:6, and the sending of an already 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenes) Son (1 John 4:9 perfect, John 3:16 aorist) as marking a pre-temporal Father-Son relation. The begetting texts are read as enthronement declarations of an already existing Son.

enthronement_sonship: qualified_affirm_with_event · Takes the begetting vocabulary at its strongest. 'To bear, beget' (yalad) in Psalm 2:7, qal (the simple active form of the Hebrew verb) perfect, and 'to beget' (gennaō) in Hebrews 1:5, Hebrews 5:5, and Acts 13:33, perfect (a completed action whose result still stands) with 'today' (σήμερον, semeron), are tied by the canon itself to a moment, and Acts 13:33 anchors the 'today' to the resurrection. On this reading the Son title or its full investiture is constituted or publicly declared at an event in time. This lens grants the pre-existence of 'the Word' (Logos) but locates the formal sonship at enthronement, and the begetting words do not lexically rank against it.

incarnational_sonship: denies_eternal_sonship · Leans on Luke 1:35, where 'will be called Son of God' (κληθήσεται υἱὸς θεοῦ) attaches the title to 'the one being born' (τὸ γεννώμενον, from 'to beget' (gennaō)), the one conceived and born. On this reading sonship names the relation the eternal Word enters at the incarnation. It must still account for John 17:24, the Father loving 'me' before the foundation of the world, which addresses the same personal subject prior to creation.

subordinationist: qualified_affirm · Accepts pre-existence but reads 'greater' (μεῖζων, meizon) in John 14:28 and Father-as-source language as marking ontological ranking. Lexically this still yields an asymmetrical relation rather than a temporal beginning for the Son.

adoptionist: denies · Treats Psalm 2:7 plus the resurrection 'today' (σήμερον, semeron) of Acts 13:33 as constituting sonship at the resurrection. This cannot account for the ongoing past form 'was' (ἦν, imperfect of 'to

be', an ongoing or repeated past action) of John 1:1-2, the 'before the world existed' (πρὸ τοῦ τὸν κόσμον εἶναι) of John 17:5, or the pre-creation 'image' (εἰκὼν, eikon) and agency predications of Colossians 1:15-17, which describe a relation already in place before creation.

The verdict turns on two bodies of vocabulary that do not rank against each other. One body (the ongoing past form 'was' (ἦν, imperfect of 'to be', an ongoing or repeated past action), 'before' (πρό) and 'alongside' (παρά) with creation-frame 'of-which' forms (genitives, the 'from-X or of-X' grammatical form), the 'in' (ἐν), 'through' (διὰ), 'toward' (εἰς) agency triad, 'firstborn' (πρωτότοκος, prototokos) preceding entry into the world, the sending of an already 'one-of-a-kind' (monogenes) Son) describes a pre-creation Father-Son relation. The other body (the begetting verbs 'to bear, beget' (yalad) and 'to beget' (gennaō), attached by the canon to 'today' (σήμερον, semeron) and the resurrection, with the future Davidic adoption formula of 2 Samuel 7:14) attaches son-installation language to a moment in time. The affirm rests on the first body, the begetting texts are read as declaration rather than origination, and a reader who weights the begetting texts as constitutive reaches a different verdict.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine whether the Son is presented in the canon as having a temporal origin or an event that constitutes his sonship, or as eternally and relationally Son of the Father.

The original stem assumes the conciliar (council-derived) vocabulary 'co-eternal' and 'co-equal', which is post-canonical formulation. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form lets the lexical pattern speak first. The verdict affirms unchanged from the prior file. The lexical evidence still supports affirm via the durative (ongoing) and pre-creation vocabulary, but confidence is lowered from high to medium because the begetting verbs 'to bear, beget' (yalad) and 'to beget' (gennaō) carry an origin sense and the canon attaches 'today, I have begotten you' to the resurrection and enthronement (Acts 13:33), and Luke 1:35 ties the 'called Son of God' title to the one being born. So the begetting and title vocabulary underdetermines whether sonship is eternal or constituted at an event. This file is flagged 'lexically-disputed' for that reason.

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License audit

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lexically-disputed · variant-sensitive · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved